SPORTS

RISING STAR

Hailing from a family of wrestlers, hockey player **Deepika** took the path less travelled—and is finally enjoying her moment in the sun

In the sporting world, we know that Haryanvi girls can land a mean punch (Saweety Boora), can outmanoeuvre on the mat (Sakshi Malik) and shoot their way to Olympic glory (Manu Bhaker). But score from a penalty corner in hockey? That's Deepika, the 21-year-old rising star of women's hockey. The drag flicker is on cloud nine, having won Hockey India's Asunta Lakra award for upcoming player of the year 2024 (Women Under-21) after being the top goal-scorer and best player at two 2024 tournaments: Bihar Women's Asian Champions Trophy and Women's Junior Asia Cup held in Oman. Belonging to a family of wrestlers, Deepika started off by following her older brother to the mat at Sports Authority of India's facility in Hisar. But her heart lay in hockey, which she would encounter there. After a year and a half watching from the sidelines, she made up her mind: "I told my father '*Mujhe hockey mein hi jaana hai. Hockey nahin toh kuchh nahin khelna*' [I want to play only hockey. If not hockey, then I won't play any sport.]" The ultimatum was dismissed as childhood rebellion and indulged. "They [family] thought that I'd get over it and grow up and come back to wrestling," she adds. Only 11 then, Deepika was deemed too young, but compelled her father to convince the coach, Azad Singh Malik. A return to wrestling was soon forgotten as Deepika quickly rose through the state and junior ranks to get called in the senior team in 2022. It's 2024, though, which has been the breakthrough year for the forward, having wowed all with her pace and precision. Deepika admits that expectations and pressures have risen, but so has her innate hunger to match

Last year was Deepika's best. The **FORWARD WOWED ALL WITH** her pace and precision

